

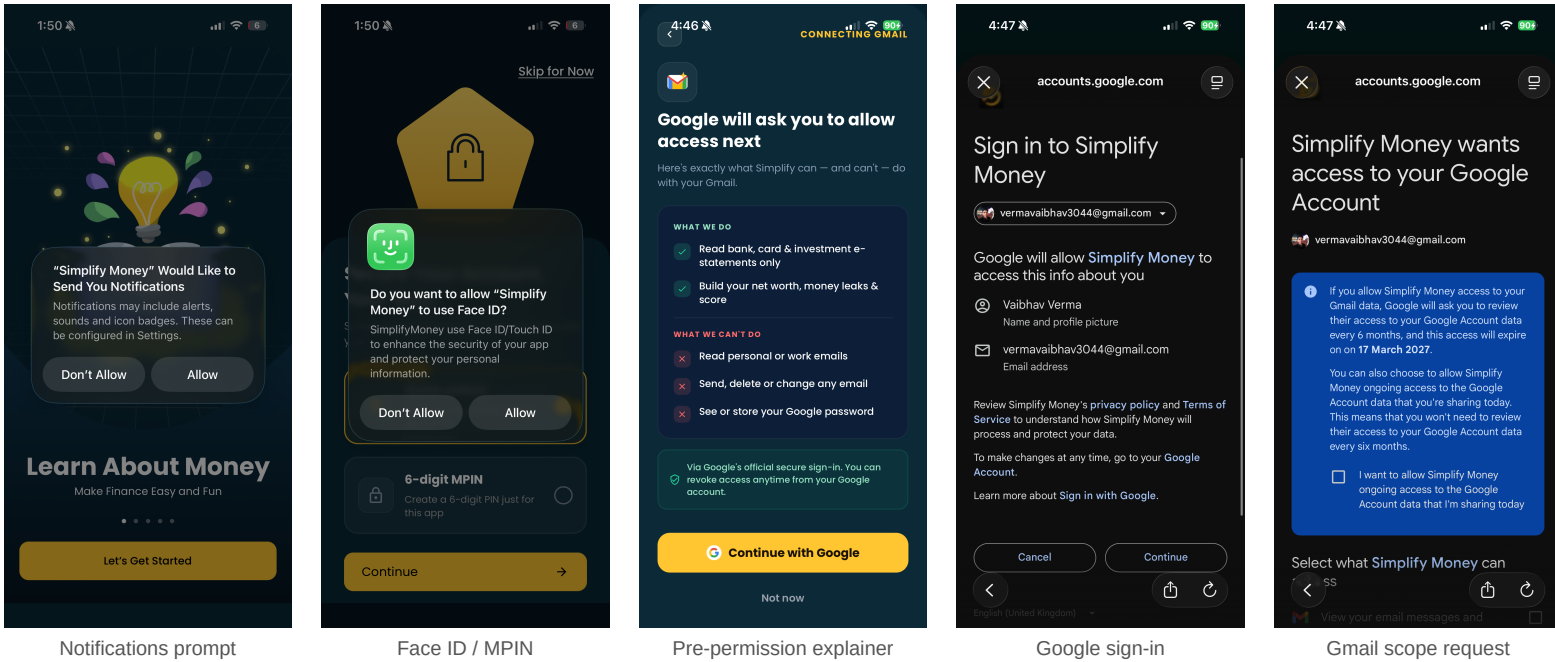
Task 1 — Track teardown

Vaibhav Verma · Simplify Money · Backend Engineer/Intern assignment · iPhone, iOS · data source connected: Gmail

What I did

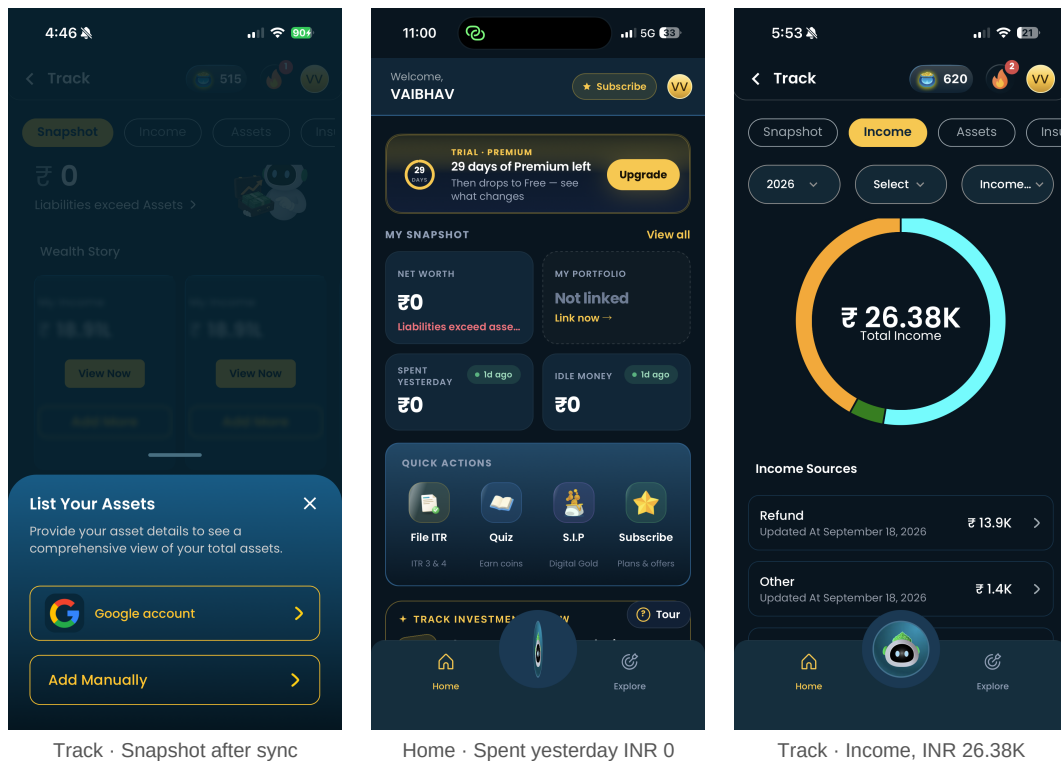
Installed Simplify Money, completed my profile, and connected Gmail as a data source. Opened Track and let it read and classify my mail. I did this before writing any code, which turned out to matter: several of the failure modes below are the same ones the assignment corpus is built from.

Stage 1 — onboarding and permissions



The pre-permission explainer is the best screen in the flow. It states what the app will and will not do, in a two-column layout, *before* handing me to Google rather than after. Most apps ask first and explain never.

Stage 2 — the sync and the result



Where it got things wrong

1. Refunds are counted as income — INR 13.9K of INR 26.38K

Track reports INR 26.38K of income for 2026, and more than half of it is a source labelled **Refund**.

A refund is not earnings. It reverses a purchase I already made. Counting it as income overstates income while the original debit stays in spending, so the same money is counted on both sides. This is the same failure mode the app's own categories already avoid for transfers between a user's own accounts, and it matters more than it looks: "how much do I earn" is the number a net worth figure and a money score are built on.

What I would expect: net the refund against the original spend where the original can be identified, or hold it in a category that is neither income nor spending. Showing it as income is the one option that is definitely wrong.

This is not a hypothetical edge case to me — the assignment corpus contains refund and reversal messages, the four categories in the spec do not cover them, and I emailed Simplify Money about exactly this case before I started building.

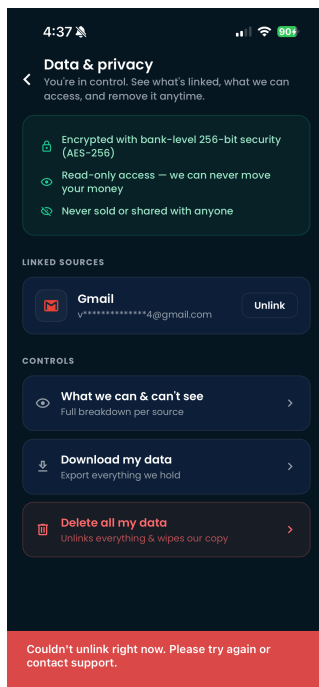
2. INR 0 spent, while INR 26.38K earned

On the home screen, **Spent yesterday** and **Idle money** both read INR 0, refreshed a day ago, while Track's Income tab reports INR 26.38K for the year. **Net worth** shows INR 0 labelled "Liabilities exceed assets", which is a clamped negative on an account where I have entered no liabilities at all.

So the app has ingested enough to produce an income figure but is showing me none of my spending. An app whose stated purpose is telling me where my money went is reporting that none of it went anywhere, and is showing a confusing derived figure instead of saying what it could not see.

My theory: on iOS there is no SMS access, so Track is working from Gmail e-statements alone. Most Indian bank debit alerts arrive by SMS and only some are mirrored by email. If that is the cause, the product is running on a fraction of the evidence and not saying so. An incomplete ledger presented as a complete one is worse than an empty state, because I cannot tell the difference between "you spent nothing" and "I could not see your spending".

3. Unlink failed on the Data & privacy screen



I tapped **Unlink** on the linked Gmail source and got "Couldn't unlink right now. Please try again or contact support."

This is a different class of problem from a miscategorised transaction. The screen exists to tell me I am in control — *"You're in control. See what's linked, what we can access, and remove it anytime"* — and the control did not work.

For an app reading financial email, revocation failing is the one error that should never be a toast message. If the backend call fails, the app should tell me what state my data is actually in, queue the request, and confirm when it completes.

Where I trusted it, and where I did not

Trusted. The pre-permission explainer, which is genuinely well done. The stated encryption and read-only posture. And the presence of "Download my data" and "Delete all my data" as first-class controls rather than buried settings — most apps handling this data do not offer either.

Did not trust, for three reasons.

The scope promise does not match the permission. The explainer says "Read bank, card & investment e-statements only" and "We can't read personal or work emails". But the scope being requested on the Google screen is Gmail read access. Google cannot enforce "statements only" — the filtering happens inside Simplify Money's own code. The wording implies a technical guarantee where there is a policy promise. I would still have granted it, but I want to be told which of the two I am relying on.

The numbers, once I saw the refund classification. If more than half of reported income is a category that should not be income, I cannot use the total for anything — and there is no way to see which transactions produced it beyond one drill-down.

The privacy controls, after Unlink failed. A control that fails once is a control I will check twice.

Three things I would change

1. Fix the refund classification, and make every figure traceable. Every total should be tappable through to the transactions that produced it, and every transaction to the messages it came from. A user who cannot see why a number is what it is has no way to catch the app being wrong, which is exactly the position I was in with the INR 13.9K. This is not a large ask: the pipeline already knows which messages produced each row — in the service I built for Task 2, every ledger entry carries its source message ids for precisely this reason.

2. Say plainly what is read, and show what could not be read. Replace "we can't read personal or work emails" with what is actually true: the app is granted read access and filters to bank senders on its own side. And surface the messages the parser could not understand, as a count at minimum. A silent drop is indistinguishable from "you had no transactions", and the user is the only one who can tell the difference. Distinguishing "this is not a transaction" from "I could not read this" is the single most useful thing this pipeline can do for trust.

3. Never let a privacy control fail into a toast. Unlink and delete should be queued and confirmed, with the resulting state visible afterwards. If it fails, tell me whether my data is still linked and what happens next.

One structural observation

If Track on iOS runs on Gmail alone, the product is missing most of its evidence on this platform. In the assignment corpus, emails account for only a small share of messages and most transactions are evidenced by SMS; several transactions appear in both channels, and one channel alone would have missed them outright. That is a platform limitation rather than a bug, but it should be said during onboarding rather than discovered by a user who is shown INR 0 spent.